

The Nativity Fast

The coming Sabbath marks the beginning of the Nativity Fast (43 days before the Birthday of Lord Jesus Christ). This is the fast Prophets fasted in the hope of the Lord First Coming to the world, for the salvation of us and be Born from Holy Mother Saint Virgin Mary. Though it is the Prophets who fasted "The Nativity Fast," all in the name of Christians fast it.

Pope Shenouda said, "Fasting is an important topic for all, as almost all nations and religions practice some form of fasting. Fasting was even established in man's doctrine before people became different nations. Fasting even goes back to the time of Adam and Eve."

Archpriest Artemy Vladimirov further explains this notion. He says, "The whole history of humankind, which began with the fall of our forefather and mother, Adam and Eve, the continuation of history through their descendants, the history of peoples and kingdoms (especially the history of ancient Israel), all led up to and arrived at Bethlehem, to the mysterious cave, where Christ the Savior of the world manifested His wondrous infant countenance to us."

"It is no surprise that even two thousand years later, we, the children of Christ's Church, do not suddenly or immediately celebrate the Lord's Nativity, but rather embark upon a forty-day fast (as the holy fathers have ordained of old), so that we might be gradually illuminated by the wondrous light of the Nativity night."

Our Savior Lord Jesus Christ came from the heavens to be born from Virgin Saint Mary onwards the 5500 years of slavery to sin, for He would liberate mankind from enemy Satan and deviousness. The Holy place Bethlehem welcomed the miraculous beginning of the Lord's work of salvation. This sacred abode is still visited by many Christians for the worship of God.

Father Rostislav Sheniloff describes it as follows. "In the Holy Land, in the town of Bethlehem, where the Lord was born in a humble manger, a majestic church now stands over the site of His birth. This church is distinguished by its entrance doors, which were made so low, that an average adult has to stoop in order to go in. This was done deliberately, to constantly remind us of the need for spiritual humility before the greatness of the event that took place here."

The word of God foretold by the Prophets is what befallen in Bethlehem. The Prophecy is avowed as "For us a Child is born, us a Son is given; And the government will be upon His shoulder. And His name will be called Wonderful, Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, and Prince of Peace." (Isaiah 9:6) Craving for this work of God, miracle and merciful act of the Lord, the Prophets has fasted for its fulfillment. Fasting embraced by prayer and prostration has the power to amend what is broken; renew the stale and foremost triumph on the evil. "It is the same path of inner knowledge of God (with all its components) that is the proper context of fasting. If we fast but do not forgive our enemies – our fasting is of no use. If we fast and do not find it drawing us into humility – our fasting is of no use. If our fasting does not make us yet more keenly aware of the fact that we are sinful before all and responsible to all then it is of no benefit. If our fasting does not unite us with the life of God – which is meek and lowly – then it is again of no benefit. Fasting is not dieting. Fasting is not about keeping a Christian kosher. Fasting is about hunger and humility (which is increased as we allow ourselves to become weak). Fasting is about allowing our heart to break," explains Father Stephen Freeman.

It is so crucial to know and understand the value of fasting as the consummation of work of salvation of God vowed for the first man Adam, through the Holy Son becoming Perfect Man.

Father Stephen affirms about fasting being the ladder to eternal life. "Why do we fast? Perhaps

the more germane question is “why do we eat?” Christ quoted Scripture to the evil one and said, “Man does not live by bread alone but by every word that proceeds from the mouth of God.” We eat as though our life depended on it and it does not. We fast because our life depends on the word of God.”

He further explains saying, “Either we know the living God or we have nothing. Either we eat His flesh and drink His blood or we have no life in us. The rejection of Hesychasm (stillness) is the source of all heresy.”

All the seven fasts recognized by Holy Church have similar aim and value though they befall on various chronologies. This fasting of the Prophets known also “The Nativity Fast,” is the beginning of the Lord’s work of Salvation. “Nativity” a word referring to “Birth or the Birth of Christ) is the naming of the Prophet’s Fast who fasted in the hope, love and mercy of the Lord to save not only those gentiles before and on prophets age, but as well as all human race.

This being our reason to fast “The Nativity,” following their footsteps, we pray, fast and be engaged on Christian endeavors throughout the fasting. Particular on recent times, we shall fast and lean more on the word of God in trepidation of Him thru Liturgy and Order of Holy Church. Brethren! We have become less fortunate when it comes to having good Religious and Patristic Fathers who can lead us to the right path. They are facing their own trail and impediments within this devious world. We are leaving in a universe filled with evil, deceptiveness, treachery, fornication and all the sinful acts disgraced by the Lord. As the days go by, we are sinking into the satanic storm and for this, we seek to have a shelter from all the deviousness and weapons in defeating the enemy. Our sturdy weapons are prayer, fasting, prostration and good deeds as we have read and learned from the fight of righteous and saints in scripted in their hagiographies.

May God’s mercy, the intercession of Saint Mary and the Prophets be with us; Amen!